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The Inner Work of Racial Justice: Healing Ourselves and
Transforming Our Communities through Mindfulness
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CHAPTER ONE PAUSING AND RECKONING



I have a dream that my four little children will one day live in a nation
where they will not be judged by the color of their skin but by the
content of their character.

—REVEREND DR. MARTIN LUTHER KING, JR.¹

But race is the child of racism, not the father.

—TA-NEHISI COATES²

The Weight of Our Racial Experience

In June 1984—twenty-one years after Dr. King bellowed the above words across the National Mall in Washington, D.C., and dropped his hope-drenched dream into our collective consciousness—I was perhaps *the* most hopeful sixteen-year-old girl in all of Hampton, Virginia.

Because despite a childhood that had often been a painful one, I had reached that moment when the dreams that had gotten me through it were actually starting to come true.

College—my passport to freedom—was just around the corner. And for the very first time, I was in love. His name was Jake. Yes, at that moment, there was more right than wrong in my world.

Which is why what Jake told me just days before I was to leave Hampton for a summer university course hit me so hard.

“My dad just kicked me out of the house,” Jake told me over the phone.

"He did *what*? *Why*?!" I said this, knowing what would come next.

"You know *why*. . . I told you how he is. It's because of us. He said no son of his is going to be dating some *black* girl. . ."

Oh, did I fail to mention that Jake and I had been raised in a world in which he was considered "white," and I, "black"?

(Micro reflection: Had you already made assumptions about Jake's race? Was the question forming in your mind? Either way, congratulate yourself: you've just brought awareness to some of the ways that your brain "does race"—i.e., the way that you make race-based assumptions and fill in the blanks as you go when reading stories, names, résumés, and so on).³

Jake had used the word *black* when he might have used some other. I knew that his father's way was something he was actively resisting. We were on the same side in this, and that meant everything.

But even with Jake's support, I still remember the pain that gripped me that afternoon, on hearing that my *race*—this category created by others that did not and could not capture much of who I really was—had made me unacceptable to my true love's family.

My race had made me the Other.

I had known that this might happen when we started dating, of course. But that did not make it any less devastating.

And I remember learning something more—that my being "a black girl" had not only made me unacceptable to Jake's working-class Virginia family, but had made me so unacceptable that they were willing to throw their own, reportedly beloved son out of their home and onto the streets like garbage.

It hit me hard that this notion that they had about me—or more accurately, about people supposedly *like* me, as they had never actually met *me*—had made me so unacceptable that they were willing to hurt their own son, and thereby themselves, and all to teach him, me, and anyone around us a multifaceted lesson.

It was a lesson about what must never come of his having been the

first generation in his family to attend a racially integrated school in the South: as a white man, Jake must not come to see black people as equally deserving of dignity, inclusion, and love.

It was a lesson about who *they*—Jake's parents—took themselves to be: people profoundly and pervasively "white" in the American South in the twentieth century. They may not have had college educations, or achieved greatness in the eyes of the world beyond their hometown. But what they had *inherited*—the cultural, sometimes economic, and psychic value of *whiteness*—meant something and was in a way defined by their willingness to reject me, to reject this thing called *blackness*. Whiteness was more valuable than the safety of their own flesh and blood.

Despite my being an A student, a model leader who would soon be named Teenager of the Year in our town, I was not good enough to be associated with them. This hurt me badly. Yet I was clearly not the only one suffering. To this day, I cannot imagine how Jake must have felt to learn the limits of his father's love. The pain we both experienced in those moments has faded over the many years. But for me, its clarifying lessons remain. What happened to me and Jake taught me a lot about racism.

Racism is a complex of behavior and explanatory stories that enable some human beings to assert power over other human beings. Though it can seem natural or simply biological, it is not. Racism depends on the social construction of what sociologists have come to refer to as "racialized" bodies, which is to say, the idea and practice of people being assigned racial labels that, as we have been trained to understand, sit in a relative hierarchy of worth in relationship to other racial labels. We often refer to people as white, black, or some other race, without thinking twice about it, as if race is a part of the natural order of things. But race is a matter of *social imagination and construction*, of *perceptions* shaped by a given context. Someone who might be considered "too white" in the Caribbean might be considered unequivocally "black" in the United States. Throughout this book, I will use the same shorthand (black, white,

Asian, Latino, and so on), but what I really mean is how a person has been racialized in the place and time in which he/she exists. Racism operates in obvious and nonobvious ways that render the target of the behavior vulnerable, by degrees, to disrespect, disadvantage, harm, or even death. Racism, in my view, is not limited to individual bad actions based on intent to harm others, nor is it limited to those individuals who consciously endorse beliefs about the inferiority of others (although such actions and beliefs would certainly fall under the definition I use here). Racism encompasses both explicit and implicit beliefs and acts that justify the assertion of power—individually, collectively, or systemically—against racially maligned people and their white allies, so as to minimize their freedom, access to resources, and sense of value in the world.

So how does the definition of racism provided above apply to the conduct of Jake's father? The behavior was the act of throwing Jake out of the house. The explanatory story was this: because no son of his was going to be dating some black girl. The power was that possessed by Jake's father—a white man who had complete control over Jake's access to safe lodging, and denied Jake that access and safety as a punishment. And because this left both Jake and me vulnerable to heartbreak and physical distress, Jake's father had asserted his power over both of us. Thus, Jake's father's reaction was an act of racism.

In witnessing and reflecting on the actions of Jake's father, I learned a hard but important lesson about race and racism in America: despite all of our own triumphant experiences in finally desegregating Virginia's public schools in the late 1970s and early '80s, white supremacy—the dominant culture's deep-seated belief that white is above black in the hierarchy of all things—had not gone away.

We had not sung it away in the "integrated" basement of the Bethel Free Will Baptist Church, whose buses entered our neighborhood every summer Sunday morning, picked up brown-skinned kids by twos and threes, and hauled us across town to a pristine sanctuary where we sat alongside white kids and sang, as loudly as we could, "*Jesus loves the little*

children, all the children of the world. Red and yellow, black and white, they are precious in his sight, Jesus loves the little children of the world!"—before being bused right back across town to our very separate and unequal homes.

No, white supremacy and racism were alive and well in hearts and minds, behind neatly trimmed yards and around the cul-de-sacs of city and suburb alike. They had not gone away, as we were given to believe, simply because the adults around us—especially the white adults, the ones in charge at our "integrated" schools—had stopped talking about them in public. And they had not gone away simply because we had been taught, under a twisted interpretation of Dr. King's inspiring words, to be "color-blind"—i.e., never to acknowledge, discuss, or respond to racism's continued existence and vitality, and instead, to pretend that none of us even "see" race.

What I learned was that the centuries-long war to end the policies and practices of white supremacy, to encourage a realignment of our allegiances in favor of *common ground* rather than our racialized identities and so-called affinity groups, had not ended. The battle over the degree to which black people and other nonwhites should be included in, or excluded from, the so-called American body politic had not been won by the civil rights movement after all.

As I came to see, we had only settled into an uneasy truce.

All it would take to inspire a new skirmish in this war would be what my romance with Jake represented: evidence that two people who had been racialized differently had, in fact, judged each other by character and not color, and for a moment, at least, found one another worthy of love.

And, as I would learn much later, all it would take to rekindle the full-out war would be the unexpected rise, through this quietly smoldering landscape, of the walking embodiment of the threat to white supremacy posed by the gains of the civil rights movement: a president of mixed racial and cultural heritage named Barack Hussein Obama.

In 2019, there are people who are surprised to see evidence of this ongoing war of inclusion/exclusion. They are shocked by its especially

antiblack character and its virulently anti-immigrant themes. They are incredulous that the legal, political, and cultural changes that have taken place since the mid-twentieth century to shift the United States toward inclusive democracy have also engendered deep resentment among those racialized white.

But I am not surprised. I lived through the clarifying summer of 1984, and have been awake to the slippery yet ever-present nature of racism ever since. I have seen how readily it can be put into service to deem certain people unlovable, to raise questions about our common humanity, and even to cut ties with one's own kith and kin.

What I learned that summer inspired in me a desire truly to understand race and racism in our everyday lives and to see them for what they are: deep and pervasive cultural conditioning for grouping others into categories and placing them at enough distance to render their suffering less visible, for obscuring our intertwined destinies, and for turning us *against* one another rather than *toward* one another when we suffer in *common*.

In short, what I learned that summer inspired my life's work: dissolving the lies that racism whispers about who we really are, and doing whatever I can to reduce the terrible harm it causes us all.

Practicing "The Pause"

You have just read a reflection on an experience of race in American life, an example of what I call a "Race Story."

For just a moment now, let us stop.

Take a moment to check in with yourself. What was it like for you to read these words? What thoughts are coming up for you? What do you feel in your body now? What emotions do you feel as you consider what you just read? And again: Where in your body are you feeling these emotions, sensing the thoughts, questions, and other reactions you're noticing now?

Throughout this book, you will be asked to stop and reflect like this. This is an embodied practice that I call "The Pause."

The Pause is an aspect of the *practice* of mindfulness meditation that can lead you to the *experience* of body-based mindfulness. What is mindfulness? It is simply paying attention, on purpose, with the attitude of friendly, open, nonjudgmental curiosity, and a willingness to accept (at least for now!) what arises.

Over the course of this book, you will be exploring and deepening the practice of mindfulness, which can be hugely important for understanding our experiences around race and identity. Mindfulness is essential to developing the capacity to *respond*, rather than simply *react* as if on autopilot, to what we experience.

To practice The Pause, you simply stop what you are doing and intentionally bring your awareness to the experience of the present moment. This is the first step in engaging in mindfulness practice.

Pausing and intentionally directing attention to particular focal points in your experience help you more routinely to focus your attention at will, clarify the mind, de-stress, and minimize any trauma-based reactions in the body.

Just for a minute, turn your attention to the sensations of breathing in and out and rest here. As you do so, notice: What thoughts are in your mind right now? See if you can release those thoughts. Practice letting them be for the moment, just as they are. It may help to imagine them as leaves falling gently from a tree, or as clouds crossing a blue sky. It may help to think of the out-breath—here and throughout the practices described in this book—as a micro practice of letting go, of coming home to the resources of peace within you.

As you bring your attention back to the sensations of breathing, what do you notice? Settle into the experience of breathing and sitting, noticing your feet on the floor, your buttocks in the chair. Feel the support that exists for you in the body and the breath at this very moment.

Now allow yourself to explore any emotions or other bodily sen-

sations arising—the sense of “I like this,” or “I don’t like this.” Open up to what your body is telling you in this moment. Try not to judge your feelings and sensations. Be as specific as you can about what you notice. Most important: as much as possible, be kind to yourself.

Later, we will look at research suggesting the value of such mindful reflection—particularly as a means of developing the embodied emotional intelligence, self-regulation, and overall resilience required to work through the challenges of examining racism in our lives. But for now, see if you can just allow yourself to get to know what is arising in you in this very moment. As you bring this Pause to a close, sense the ground beneath you as you breathe in and out. Settle into the support of *this* breath, this connection with the earth, this deepening grounding in awareness.

Finally, if you can, take a few minutes to write about what has come up for you during your Pause. This is especially important if you experienced strong emotions, or if some of your own memories or Race Stories emerged from their buried places. In my own experience, and as research has shown, even short periods of writing about emotionally difficult events in our past can assist us in deep healing.⁴

As you continue reading, engage in the loving awareness practice of The Pause whenever you need additional support.

CHAPTER TWO

SITTING WITH COMPASSIONATE RACIAL AWARENESS



Biologically speaking, we are programmed toward being tribal as a means of survival. We literally have to transcend an aspect of our own biology.

—REVEREND ANGEL KYODO WILLIAMS¹

Population geneticists agree that all of us are literally one human family. What would our world be like if everyone acted on this truth?

—SHARON SALZBERG²

Mindfulness of the Racialized Self

What we call the self is shaped by the cultures in which we live. And because race is a cultural feature of societies built on racism, notions of self include notions of race. The racialized self is produced by and helps reproduce racism in our cultures. Mindfulness helps us understand and expand our notions of self. And yet, talking about race and racism and examining these through the lens of mindfulness is uncommon. This is not to say that it is not being done at all. But many practitioners of mindfulness have been taught, whether explicitly or implicitly, that looking at racism and exploring efforts to address it—or to otherwise engage in talk